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LOVE BEER. LOVE LIFE. SINCE 1986.

It all started in 1986. Sure, many things have changed since the early days of Harpoon, but much has stayed the same. We still love brewing beer and enjoying it with friends. Below are a few highlights and some of our favorite memories from the past 30 years!

1986: THE BEGINNING...

It all started with three college buddies and a shared love of beer. Dan Kenary, Rich Doyle, and George Ligeti were passionate about beer, but they weren't able find what they were looking for on tap at their local pubs. While traveling in Europe after college, they drank many diverse, fresh, local beers and experienced firsthand the wonderful beer culture that existed just across the pond.

They wanted to bring that to Boston, so they decided to do just that. In 1986 the Harpoon Brewery received Brewing Permit #001 in the Commonwealth of Massachusetts. And that, friends, was the beginning of Harpoon....

We had the building, brewing equipment, and a bunch of people who loved to drink beer....now we just needed someone to come and actually brew the beer. Enter Russ Heissner, a graduate of the UC Davis School of Fermentation Sciences. Russ started formulating the recipe for Harpoon Ale in the summer of 1986. Friends and family were the lucky (and, at times, unlucky) quality control team through many months of test batches. Finally, in June of 1987 the "original" Harpoon Ale was brewed and delivered to Harpoon's first accounts; the Sevens Ale House on Charles Street and Doyle's Café in Jamaica Plain. And the rest, as they say, is history. But read on for more anyway.



1988 – 1990: A COUPLE OF “FIRSTS” FOR HARPOON

Harpoon Winter Warmer is introduced! A beer with cinnamon and nutmeg in it – are you crazy?! That's mostly what we heard when we first started bringing Harpoon Winter Warmer to friends and family. It was, after all, the first craft beer seasonal brewed in New England. Although some people thought it was a little strange that we brewed a beer with spices in it, Harpoon Winter Warmer quickly became the beer synonymous with the New England winter, and our most anticipated seasonal every year.

A couple year's later, we did another Harpoon “first” – Harpoon



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1993 – 2000: HARPOON IPA IS CREATED AND WE BUY A BREWERY



It’s hard to believe these days, but back in the early 90s, IPAs weren’t as ubiquitous as they are now. In fact, there were very few brewed on the east coast. In the early 1990s, hoppy Pale Ales were being brewed in the Pacific Northwest and California but there were no craft beers being brewed in the rest of the US that featured high aroma content from Northwest hops. Harpoon IPA was a very extreme beer for 1993. Would beer drinkers be ready for the hoppiness of an IPA?YES. Instead of shying away from the hops, beer drinkers embraced them. Our IPA quickly became our bestselling beer and flagship. It made the brewery what it is today.

Then in 2000, we purchased the former Catamount Brewery in Windsor, VT. The craft beer fire was catching, and we continued to grow at a rapid pace. Our digs in Boston could no longer accommodate the insatiable thirst of New England beer lovers. We were brewing at full capacity at our facility in Boston – 24 hours a day, seven days a week – but we continued to struggle to keep up with the demand for Harpoon. As luck would have it, an incredible opportunity came our way – a beautifully constructed relatively new brewery built by the Catamount Brewery, another pioneering New England craft brewer, went up for sale. In June of 2000 we became the proud owners of a new, state-of-the-art brewery in Windsor, Vermont. We still brew some of the Catamount beers from time to time – be sure to follow us on social to learn more about these special releases!

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every day. The annual Harpoon 5-Miler is the perfect illustration of our motto. Our first race was May 2001 and since then, every year we have close to 5,000 runners jamming out 5 miles around our brewery in Boston, ending at the brewery for some beers to celebrate. The best part is that the run benefits an organization that is near and dear to our hearts, The Angel Fund. Since we started the 5-Miler, we've raised more than \$1,300,000 to support their cause in finding a cure for ALS. A little exercise, followed by beers, while raising money for a truly worthy cause. That's Love Beer. Love Life.

Harpoon 5-Miler's success proved one thing: beer lovers are good people. At least the ones we know. So, we decided to start a program that harnesses all this goodness and to give back to our community. Harpoon Helps was created in 2003 to organize our community outreach. Our mission is to support local charities throughout our distribution footprint with donations of fresh Harpoon beer and volunteer hours, and by raising money for organizations through events. Harpoon Helps produces 6 fundraising events throughout the year. Harpoon Helps is something that we're very proud of here at the brewery. Other than brewing great beer, being a good neighbor ranks high on our "To Do" list.



2025: NEW CITY, SAME BEER

We're honored to share our brews with friends across the country, but we've always been especially proud of our New England roots. There's something about the craft beer community here – a shared pride, a passion for quality, and a deep local loyalty – that feels like home.

So when it came time to expand, we quickly looked to our New Hampshire neighbors. Following in the footsteps of our Boston and Windsor breweries, we knew Harpoon's next home had to be rich in history, culture, and a passion for craft beer. And that's exactly what we found in Manchester, New Hampshire!

From the historic mills and architecture, to the elite athletics and entertainment venues, to the thriving art scene and historic theatres, to the loads of outdoor adventures...we could go on and on and on! Long story short: Manchester felt like the perfect new home to Love Beer. Love Life.

Harpoon joined the development of Queens City Center located in the heart of downtown Manchester – a walkable, bikeable hub of creativity and community. Our newest location sits right next to the iconic former R.G. Sullivan Cigar Company building, one of the largest cigar manufacturers in the country from 1906 to 1963. Pretty cool, right? Our neighbors have some history, and we're pulling up a chair and a beer.



2026: IPA GETS A REFRESH

Harpoon IPA's look has changed quite a bit over the years — but the beer inside has always been the same bright, floral, and crisp IPA that first hit New England in 1993. As Boston's first craft brewery (Brewing Permit

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time outside of Boston’s longest-standing establishments.

We were the first IPA many New Englanders ever tried, and we’ve been brewing it the same way ever since — balanced, approachable, and reliably good whether you’re at a backyard cookout, a neighborhood bar, or heading into Fenway. This new look isn’t about changing who we are. It’s about owning it. It honors the scrappy early days, celebrates the community that built us, and sets us up for what’s next. Same beer. Same spirit. Just a sharper jacket.

Cheers to the next 40 years.



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